

size, try the Iomega 20 GB hard drive, which comes in a manageable size and was the lightest of the bunch. This drive has just one LED that doubles up as the power indicator and the data transfer indicator, and it doesn't score badly in the looks department either. However, the Iomega requires a special converter for its power adapter to fit into Indian power sockets.

Shifting our focus to the Zip drives, the ice blue Iomega Zip 250 MB drive was the first to catch our attention. Rubber pads on either sides of the drive give it a good grip on the desk and a stand enables it to be placed vertically—an excellent space-saving feature. A feature that further enhances its portability is the fact that it draws power from the USB port and thus does not require an external power supply. Although the Iomega drive paints a pretty picture and features some nifty features, its build quality could have been better. For instance, the absence of a manual eject button means that if the Zip medium gets stuck, you will be forced to open the drive up, causing the drive damage. Moving on to its elder brother, the

Iomega Zip 750, this drive looks just as good as its sibling and improves on the former's weak build quality. But this drive too does not feature a manual eject button and requires external power.

Among the portable CD-Writers, the Plextor PX-W2410A is capable of burning CDs at a maximum speed of 24x and comes in a compact design and a durable metallic



The Iomega Zip 750 drive doesn't feature a manual eject button and requires external power

Maintenance Tips



- Always handle the device with outmost care when on the move; even the slightest jerks could damage the drive.
- Carry the device in a cushioned pack or wrapped in a bubble wrap to absorb shock.
- Do not place the device on an uneven surface as this could damage the internal mechanism while the drive is powered on.
- Always use branded media as it ensures better data integrity.
- While in use, keep the device away from high voltage devices such as monitors to protect it from Electro Magnetic Interference (EMI).

body. But the characteristics that impart the drive sturdiness also take away from its appearance, lending it a none-too-pleasing boxy look. The power switch is non-intuitively placed on the back of the drive. The bundled accessories include one CD-RW disk and burning software in the form of Nero 5.5. It disappointed us, however, by leaving out the power cable.

The Yamaha CRW-70 wears a retro look in eye-pleasing colours. An array of buttons on the drive's front panel assures ease of control and it provides inputs for the Line In and Line Out connectors. The CRW-70 also hosts an LCD screen on the front panel and the slide button provided underneath the drive provides a hassle-free solution, in case your CD gets stuck inside the drive. However, a flip-open design for loading CDs increases the chances of dust finding its way into the drive and collecting on its delicate lens.

The ASUS CRW-4012A-U is an impressive 40x Writer with

Decision Maker			
	A portable CD-Writer	A portable hard drive	A Zip drive
What will I get out of the portable device?	Lowest cost per MB, easy of use, medium price, medium performance, high compatibility, high availability of media	Low cost per MB, high performance, cumbersome to use, high purchase cost	Low performance, low availability of media, medium cost per MB, not very easy to use
I work with image editing and page layout software	CD-RW s are not known for their speed and therefore not suited to large-volume print applications. Opt for this only if price is a barrier Solution: Plextor PX-W2410A (Rs 12,950)	Hard drives are known for their high performance. Opt for this solution if you need high performance with no issues towards price Solution: Freecom FHD-1 20 GB (Rs 15,500)	Go in for these drives only if a Zip disk is the preferred medium of data exchange amongst your clients Solution: Iomega Zip 750 MB (Rs 10,700)
I edit audio and video files	If your work involves relatively smaller file sizes, CD-Writers are recommended as they are low priced Solution: ASUS CRW-4012A-U (Rs 12,500)	The best solution for large AV productions, hard disks offer great performance but at a high price Solution: Freecom FHD-1 60 GB (Rs 20,500)	Not recommended due to low performance, relatively lower capacity of media and rare availability of media Solution: None recommended
I am a home or a small office user	Highly recommended due to low cost and wide availability of media Solution: ASUS CRW-4012A-U (Rs 12,500)	Recommended only if price is not an issue and your work involves very large amount of data Solution: Freecom FHD-1 60 GB (Rs 20,500)	Not recommended due to low availability of media Solution: None recommended
I have very basic backup needs	Highly recommended due to media's inherently higher shelf life, and low cost of media and easy availability Solution: ASUS CRW-4012A-U (Rs 12,500)	Not recommended due to high cost and relative frailty of medium Solution: None recommended	Not recommended due to low availability of media and a relatively high cost Solution: None recommended